ZTA Design Clinic Grading Guide

How to grade each team's work, the rubric, the proficiency levels, what a good answer looks like at each level, and a scoresheet. **Proctor only.** Use it alongside the **ZTA Design Clinic Solution Guide**, which holds the reference answers.

How to use this guide. This is the "how to grade" companion to the Solution Guide (the "answers"). Score each use case out of 100 against the rubric, add the scores, and award the group a single cumulative level. The proficiency levels below are a facilitation framework, calibrate them with your SME before the event.

How grading works

Each use case is scored out of **100 points**, split across three criteria:

- **Mapping, 40 pts:** how well the design addresses the customer's pain points and requirements.
- **Products, 30 pts:** the right Cisco products, with how they work and why they were chosen.
- **Diagram, 30 pts:** the clarity and correctness of the proposed design.

The Associate / Professional / Expert level is awarded to the whole group on the cumulative score, not per use case. Use cases 1-3 are required (a core total out of 300); use cases 4-5 are bonus (all five together out of 500).

Associate

All three required use cases completed, cumulative score below 70% (under 210 of 300).

A working grasp of the fundamentals. The three required use cases are attempted with the right general direction, but the cumulative score is below 70%.

Professional

All three required use cases completed with a cumulative score of 70% or higher (210 of 300 or more). A perfect three-use-case result is Professional.

Solid, correct designs across the three required use cases: right products, correct integrations, and most requirements addressed. Attempting the two bonus use cases is encouraged but not required for this level.

Expert

All five use cases attempted with a cumulative score of 80% or higher (400 of 500 or more).

Mastery across the full brief: all five use cases are designed and the cumulative score is 80% or above, with Cisco differentiators articulated throughout.

Level thresholds

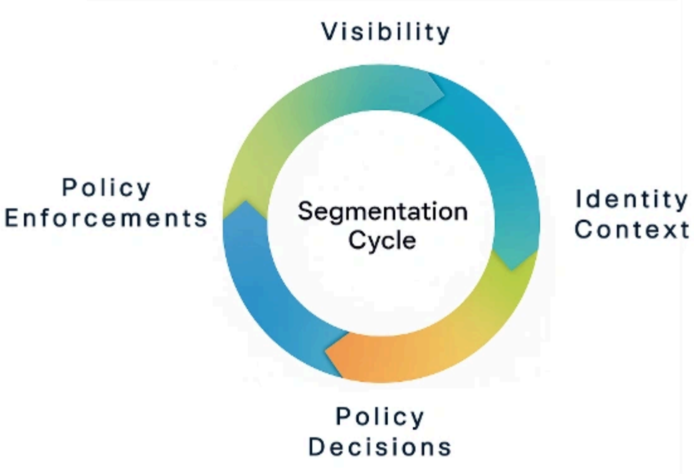
Add the use case scores, then read the group level from this table.

LEVEL	USE CASES COMPLETED	CUMULATIVE SCORE	POINTS
Associate	All three required use cases (UC1-UC3)	Under 70%	Below 210 / 300
Professional	All three required use cases (UC1-UC3)	70% or higher	210 / 300 or more
Expert	All five use cases (UC1-UC5)	80% or higher	400 / 500 or more

> **Key rule.** A group that completes only the three required use cases can reach **Professional** at most, even with a perfect score, because **Expert** requires attempting all five use cases with a cumulative 80% or higher. A group that attempts all five but scores under 80% is leveled on the three required use cases (70% or higher is Professional, otherwise Associate).

The Segmentation Cycle

Teams design against this method; a strong answer moves through all four stages.



The rubric

Score each criterion independently using the band that best fits, then add the three scores.

Mapping / 40 pts

How well the design addresses the customer’s pain points and requirements.

LEVEL	POINTS	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
Expert	36-40	Every pain point and requirement is mapped explicitly and correctly, with sound reasoning.
Professional	30-35	Nearly all pain points and requirements are addressed with correct, specific responses.
Associate	24-29	Most pain points are addressed; some requirements are vague or missing.
Developing	0-23	Misreads the scenario; few pain points or requirements are addressed.

Products / 30 pts

The right Cisco products, with how they work and why they were chosen.

LEVEL	POINTS	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
Expert	27-30	Correct products with clear Cisco differentiators (why Cisco wins), including advanced or bonus capabilities.
Professional	23-26	Correct products with correct integrations; explains how each one works.
Associate	18-22	Names the main products and what they do, but says little about why.
Developing	0-17	Wrong or missing products; cannot explain how they work.

Diagram / 30 pts

The clarity and correctness of the proposed network design.

LEVEL	POINTS	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
Expert	27-30	Clear, complete diagram; shows enforcement points, integrations, and how it extends the cumulative design.
Professional	23-26	Accurate diagram showing the main components and traffic flows for this use case.
Associate	18-22	Basic diagram; key elements are present but incomplete or unclear.
Developing	0-17	No diagram, or one that doesn't reflect the proposed design.

How to grade a team, step by step

1. **Score each use case.** For every use case, use the rubric to score Mapping (out of 40), Products (out of 30) and Diagram (out of 30) independently, then add them for that use case's total out of 100. Compare the team's work against the reference answer in the ZTA Design Clinic Solution Guide.
2. **Add the cumulative totals.** Add the three required use cases (UC1-UC3) for the required total out of 300. If the team attempted the two bonus use cases, add all five for the full total out of 500.
3. **Award the group level.** Apply the cumulative rules: all three required at 70% or higher (210 of 300) is Professional, below that is Associate; all five attempted at 80% or higher (400 of 500) is Expert. A perfect three-use-case result is Professional, since Expert requires all five.
4. **Give feedback.** Write two things the team did well and two things to improve. Be specific, point to the exact pain point, product or diagram element.
5. **Record on the scoresheet.** Enter each use case total, the cumulative totals and percentages, and the awarded group level on the team scoresheet.

Grading principles

- Grade against the reference answer, not one exact wording, reward valid alternative designs that still meet the requirements.
- Award partial credit generously. The goal is learning and better customer conversations, not gatekeeping.
- Reward articulation of Cisco differentiators, explaining why Cisco wins is the core SE skill this clinic builds.
- Score the three criteria independently before totalling, so a strong diagram doesn't mask weak product reasoning (or the reverse).
- The level is cumulative for the whole group, not per use case. Apply the same rubric to all five use cases; UC1-UC3 are required and UC4-UC5 are bonus.
- A group that attempts all five but scores under 80% is leveled on the three required use cases (70% or higher is Professional, otherwise Associate).
- For the key points to reward on each use case, see the “Proctor, what to reward” note in the Solution Guide.

Calibrate first. Before the event, have all proctors score the same sample answer together and compare results. Align on what earns each point on the rubric so scoring is consistent from table to table. Aim to grade in a few minutes per use case, then total the scores to set the group level.

What a strong answer looks like, per use case

Use these as calibration anchors for the **per-use-case score**. They describe answer quality from a basic to a complete, differentiated response, use them with the rubric point ranges to set the Mapping, Products and Diagram marks. (These describe answer quality; the Associate / Professional / Expert designation is the group's cumulative outcome, see Level thresholds above.) Each use case also lists **SME verification questions** (from the SME Cheat Sheet) to test real understanding, a team that only name-drops products but can't answer these has not earned full marks. Full reference answers are in the Solution Guide.

Use Case #1: Managed Environment; Segmentation Required

LEVEL	WHAT A TEAM AT THIS LEVEL TYPICALLY PRODUCES
Associate	Uses ISE to authenticate users and proposes group-based segmentation for Employees, IoT, deskagents and Guest; a workable campus/branch diagram. May still rely on VLANs or omit Posture and the PCI angle.
Professional	Uses SGTs instead of VLAN/IP subnets; ISE authenticates and profiles (802.1X / MAB / WebAuth) and assigns an SGT per group; the SGT Matrix enforces IoT, Guest and Mac-mini access; ISE Posture remediates out-of-date PCs. Diagram shows ISE and SGT enforcement across campus, branch and the data center.
Expert	All of the above, plus the differentiators: SGTs are topology-independent and extend end-to-end into multicloud data centers, segmentation needs no new firewalls (the budget pain), and SGACLs are more efficient than IP ACLs. Adds pxGrid Rapid Threat Containment and Secure Workload App Dependency Mapping, and ties each response to a specific pain or requirement.

SME VERIFICATION QUESTIONS

- Did the group use SGTs correctly, and do they understand dynamic vs. static SGT assignment?
- Do they understand how ISE profiling works, and how ISE Posture checks AV/OS (real-time vs. continuous)?
- Can they explain SGT Matrix operations for the group-to-group rules (IoT, Guest, Mac-mini)?
- Do they recognise that SGTs alone may not satisfy PCI where L7 inspection is required?
- Can they explain SGACL efficiency, pxGrid / Rapid Threat Containment, and Secure Workload?

Use Case #2: Remote Worker: Zero Trust Access Required

LEVEL	WHAT A TEAM AT THIS LEVEL TYPICALLY PRODUCES
Associate	Proposes Cisco Secure Access / ZTNA for remote access and Duo for identity, with a basic SASE idea. May miss clientless RDP for contractors or the Secure Web Gateway specifics.
Professional	Uses the Zero Trust Access module for per-application access (full VPN only for legacy apps); Secure Web Gateway blocks gambling and gaming; contractors get clientless browser access; Duo Passport for SSO; Duo Directory replaces the costly Okta IdP; SD-WAN integrates with Secure Access for SASE. Diagram shows the Secure Client modules through Secure Access to apps and branches.

LEVEL	WHAT A TEAM AT THIS LEVEL TYPICALLY PRODUCES
Expert	All of the above, plus the differentiators: least-privilege ZTA versus over-permissive VPN, Duo Passport OS-level SSO, passwordless to end credential theft, VPN traffic mapped to an SGT for segmentation, and a single unified policy. Every pain point and requirement is mapped.

SME VERIFICATION QUESTIONS

- Can they explain the difference between ZTNA and full-client VPN, and when to position each?
- Do they understand how the Secure Web Gateway blocks the gambling/gaming categories?
- Can they explain Duo SSO / Passport and passwordless, and why Duo IdP beats Okta on cost and security?
- Can they explain Cisco SASE (Secure Access + Catalyst SD-WAN) and its advantages?
- Why is clientless RDP a common contractor ask, and what are the risks?

Use Case #3: AI Access and Agent Controls Required

LEVEL	WHAT A TEAM AT THIS LEVEL TYPICALLY PRODUCES
Associate	Recognises the need to control AI usage and proposes Secure Access AI Access and/or Duo with basic guardrails. May miss the MCP-server and desktop-agent controls.
Professional	Uses AI Access for shadow-AI visibility and guardrails; the AI Gateway to register and govern MCP servers; Secure Client with agentic client discovery to control desktop agents; tenant control for the corporate ChatGPT tenant; and Duo IdP with agent registration (DCR). Addresses all four pain points.
Expert	All of the above, plus semantic inspection to block risky models, fine-grained per-tool authorization via the Duo / Secure Access MCP integration, and the Secure Access DLP + Cisco AI Defense story, and explains why Duo IdP is the easiest AI Gateway integration.

SME VERIFICATION QUESTIONS

- Do they understand the AI Gateway architecture and what MCP is?
- Do they understand Secure Access tenant control for the corporate ChatGPT tenant?
- Do they understand the value of Duo IdP, agent registration (DCR) and OAuth for MCP services?
- Do they understand the risks of public AI models and how semantic inspection helps?

Use Case #4: Merger / Acquisition; Extend Segmentation Bonus

LEVEL	WHAT A TEAM AT THIS LEVEL TYPICALLY PRODUCES
Associate	Proposes extending segmentation to the acquired site using FTD and using Duo for the acquired users. A basic, workable idea.
Professional	Uses FTD inline SGT tagging over a site-to-site tunnel to extend TrustSec; Duo Directory via SCIM to host the 100 users without full onboarding; Duo SSO routing for Okta coexistence; source/destination SGTs to restrict access to Site 9951; and Duo passwordless for the breached users.
Expert	All of the above, plus the differentiators: Cisco's inline SGT-tagging advantage, Security Cloud Control (SCC) to push unified SGT policy into SD-WAN, minimal authentication disruption during transition, and phishing-resistant passwordless. All pains and requirements mapped.

SME VERIFICATION QUESTIONS

- Do they understand FTD inline SGT tagging to extend TrustSec, and source/destination SGT policy?
- Do they understand Duo Directory and importing users from Okta via SCIM?
- Do they understand Duo SSO routing for Okta coexistence, and passwordless for the breached users?
- Can they explain how SCC provides unified SGT policy management?

Use Case #5: Zero Trust across multicloud Data Centers Bonus

LEVEL	WHAT A TEAM AT THIS LEVEL TYPICALLY PRODUCES
Associate	Proposes Cisco Secure Workload for visibility and segmentation across the clouds. A basic idea that may miss Kubernetes and runtime protection.
Professional	Uses Secure Workload App Dependency Mapping for discovery and auto-baseline microsegmentation across on-prem, AWS and Azure; Isovalent (Cilium / eBPF / Tetragon) for Kubernetes; Security Cloud Control (SCC) to unify consoles; and ISE common policy shared via pxGrid. Addresses budget, native-features and complexity.
Expert	All of the above, plus the differentiators: one end-to-end policy across ISE, Secure Workload and FTD via pxGrid, kernel-level eBPF protection, compensating controls (segmentation + runtime protection) for unpatchable IoT, and CSW-FTDv sync for virtual appliances. Complete mapping.

SME VERIFICATION QUESTIONS

- Do they understand Secure Workload, agent/agentless, App Dependency Mapping, auto-baseline policy?
- Do they understand CSW + FTD integration, and CSW-FTDv policy sync for virtual appliances?
- Do they understand Isovalent (Cilium / eBPF / Tetragon) for Kubernetes and runtime protection?
- Do they understand ISE common policy via pxGrid for end-to-end, and SCC to unify consoles?

Team scoresheet

Team / table #: ______________________

USE CASE		MAPPING /40	PRODUCTS /30	DIAGRAM /30	TOTAL /100
UC1	Required				
UC2	Required				
UC3	Required				
UC4	Bonus				
UC5	Bonus				
Required total (UC1-UC3)					/ 300
Full total (UC1-UC5, if all attempted)					/ 500

CUMULATIVE GROUP LEVEL (CIRCLE ONE)

Required % = required total ÷ 300 × 100 = __________ %

Full % = full total ÷ 500 × 100 = __________ %

- ☐ **Associate** — All three required use cases completed, cumulative score below 70% (under 210 of 300).
- ☐ **Professional** — All three required use cases completed with a cumulative score of 70% or higher (210 of 300 or more). A perfect three-use-case result is Professional.
- ☐ **Expert** — All five use cases attempted with a cumulative score of 80% or higher (400 of 500 or more).

Overall, what the team did well

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Overall, where they can improve

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Acronyms (SGT, ISE, ZTNA, SASE, SWG, MCP, DCR, CSW, pxGrid, eBPF…) are defined in the **glossary of the ZTA Design Clinic Solution Guide**.